

STATE REVIEW LEARNINGS:

UNIVERSITY OF ARKANSAS AT LITTLE ROCK

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

On-Site Review: February 26–27, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from both state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, “Candidate Recruitment and Completion,” is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, “Preparing Candidates Effectively,” criteria to assess performance results from document review, observations, and focus group conversations with stakeholders, including teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders and teachers, faculty, and the DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, “Supporting Workforce Needs,” are based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two

BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two
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UA LITTLE ROCK

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

Overall Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	APPROACHING

STANDARD 1: RECRUITMENT & COMPLETION

Standard 1 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	BELOW	BELOW
Recommendations		
UA Little Rock's alternative program has seen a decline in enrollment over the years. Recruiting additional candidates to increase overall enrollment, particularly in subject shortage areas, will support the program's Standard 1 performance moving forward. Additionally, consider what additional supports those candidates may need to increase the 3-year completion rate. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 1.2b, Criteria 1.3a)</i>		

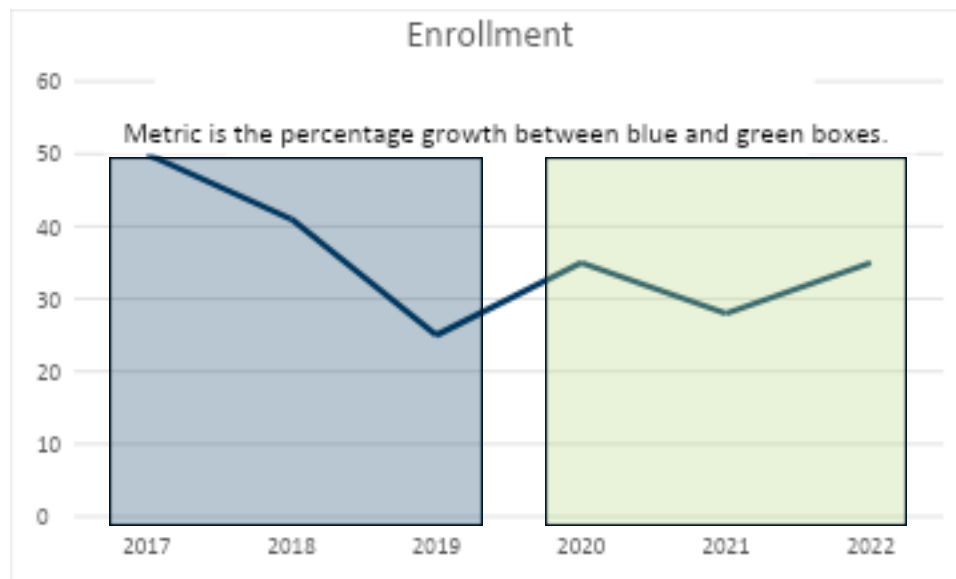
INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a: Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (I.e.; Standards 1-3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	EPPs were not asked to submit formal plans to meet the state review framework targets or to show evidence of acting on their plans as part of the Spring 2024 review cycle. As a result, all EPPs in this cycle will receive a rating of MEETS.

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

Criteria 1.2a: Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their program size and Arkansas's workforce needs

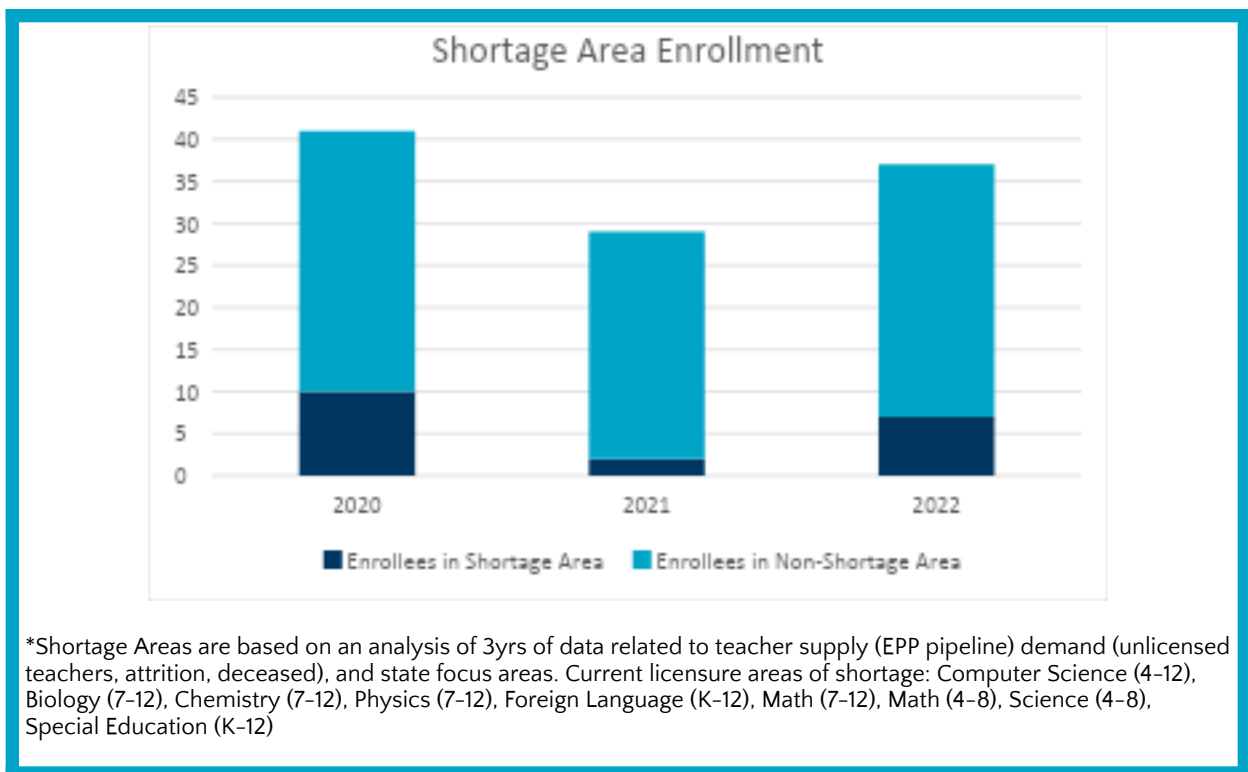
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Growth in 3yr Average Enrollment	Performance Level
Percentage growth in 3yr average enrollment	10%	-15.5%	BELOW



*The enrollment growth target was established with the aim of closing the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a "Meets" rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an "Exceeds" rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.

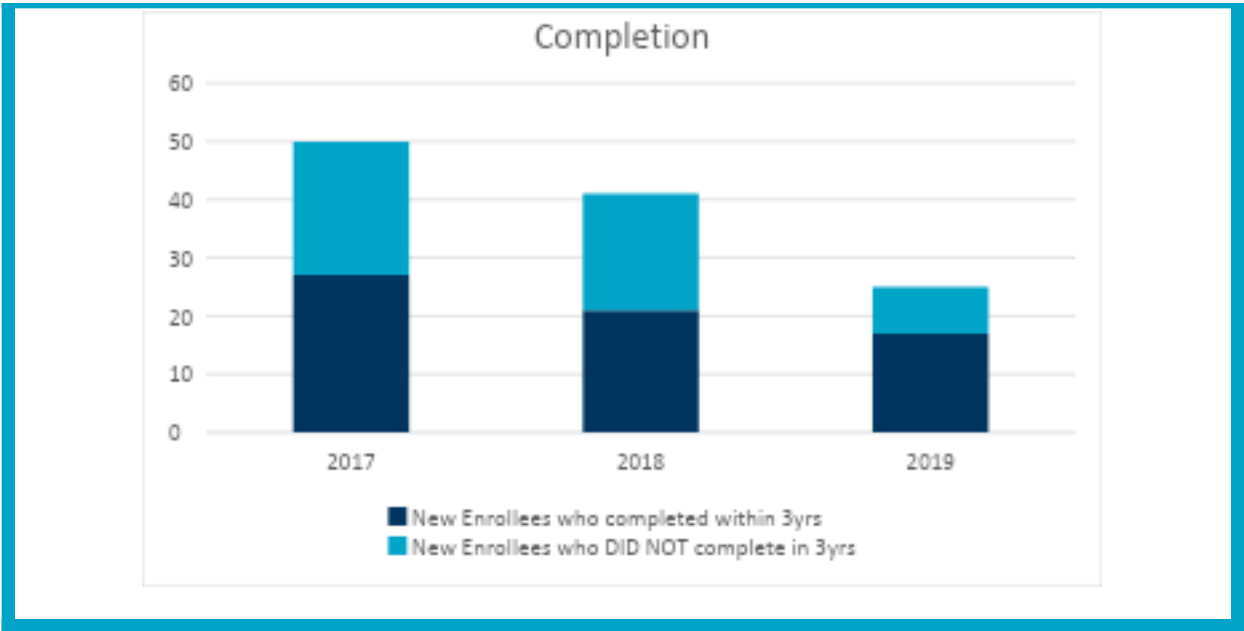
Criteria 1.2b: Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas in proportion to the need

Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of New Enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	18%	APPROACHING



INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a: Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	75%	56%	BELOW



Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	MEETS
Recommendations		
Candidate development is a strength of the UA Little Rock's alternative program. Candidates receive coursework delivered by knowledgeable and effective course instructors who support their development as teachers. The program provides online and in-person opportunities for working professionals to earn their teaching license while continuing to teach full-time. Recommendations to strengthen candidate preparation include: - Audit coursework for classroom connections, ensuring that instructors provide models of instruction and clearly and intentionally familiarize candidates with 2023 Arkansas K-12 standards. This includes providing opportunities to vertically integrate standards throughout all grade bands within their licensure area and ensuring that an increase in coursework rigor is clear to students so they can see how one course builds off another. Clearly and intentionally incorporate Arkansas Teaching Standards in activities and assignments. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 2.1a Metric 2, Criteria 2.1b Metric 2)</i> - Document a clear and intentional process to fully support candidates in their internship experience and identify mentor teachers in their buildings who can also support them. Build and maintain strong relationships with schools where teacher candidates work that may be outside the Little Rock area. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 2.2b Metric 2, 2.2c Metric 1)</i> - Support candidates so that not only struggling candidates receive extra support but also high performers receive opportunities and feedback that encourage retention. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 2.3b Metric 4)</i> - Begin preparing now to meet the state's one-year residency requirement that will apply to spring 2027 completers and beyond. Formalize systems and structures to ensure that the mentor teachers and clinical supervisors working with candidates in the building are experienced, very effective, and, by the 2026-2027 school year, have received the DESE-recognized coaching training. <i>(Focus Area: Criteria 2.2b)</i>		

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a: Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based
APPROACHING
Metric 1: Incorporation and demonstration of best practices around content instruction
APPROACHING
Coursework clearly and intentionally incorporates nationally recognized best practices around content instruction. The alternative program at UA Little Rock is primarily online, though in-person class options are available. Though a primarily online program, multiple pieces of evidence were submitted to showcase best practices, including syllabi

demonstrating best practices for technology in education and detailed objective mapping for the Middle Childhood pathway courses that include how participants learn. The HIST 4397/5397 History Teaching Applications (HIST 4397/5397) syllabus references the evaluation of instructional materials. Multiple syllabi include various teaching strategies and assignments such as readings, discussions, lesson planning, training, projects, and Blackboard assignments.

The UA Little Rock team worked with US Prep to consider student assessments and make data-informed course development decisions. No evidence was submitted to incorporate HQIM into the curriculums. However, as it is being rolled out into traditional programs first, resources are not yet physically available to participants in the alternative programs.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas K12 standards in coursework as a foundation for teacher development
APPROACHING

Coursework somewhat familiarizes candidates with Arkansas K-12 Standards throughout all grade bands within the licensure area. Nearly all course syllabi list standards but may not say explicitly how they will be incorporated into each lesson. In the focus group with course instructors, all instructors expressed using Arkansas K-12 standards in their coursework.

There was no evidence submitted or observed to demonstrate opportunities to vertically integrate standards throughout all grade bands within a licensure area.

Criteria 2.1b: Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher
APPROACHING

Metric 1: Sequence and progression of courses
MEETS

Courses are clearly and intentionally sequenced across programs of study to build on previous coursework, providing candidates with an opportunity to show proficiency. In the documents provided, there is a clear sequence and alignment in the Programs of Study for all licensure areas. Degree plans lay out the required courses and culminate in the internship experience. The "Detailed Objective Mapping" document highlights which courses introduce content, practice, and develop the skill or tool taught.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards in coursework
APPROACHING

Coursework somewhat incorporates Arkansas Teaching Standards in a way that develops candidates to meet the knowledge and skills required for their licensure area. In the syllabi for EDFN 7370 Educational Assessment (EDFN 7370), Standard 6 is the focus of the course, while the course objectives for TCED7103 Interactive Technology in Middle School (TCED7103) focus on components of 5 of the standards. All matrices submitted showed alignment with the standards and TESS. However, in the evidence provided, it was unclear how this alignment is articulated to candidates in the course's facilitation.

Metric 3: Alignment of coursework to clinical experience
MEETS

Coursework is clearly and intentionally aligned with the clinical experience. Many strong links between the course and clinical experience are illustrated. TCED courses directly prepare and support students who are in the classroom or completing a clinical internship. In the course instructor focus group, a graduate instructor explained, "The internships are laid out in sequence...instructional skills and methods come in the fall. They're primarily designed as (an) introduction to what very first courses are taking to get them out (to the clinical experience)."

Candidates consistently have opportunities to reflect on and articulate the alignment in reflection assignments in syllabi.

Additionally, Governance meeting data shows the districts and UA Little Rock faculty whether teacher candidates are doing well and where they need additional support. The EPP uses this information to adjust coursework offerings in real time to ensure that current interns are supported and that future interns have what they need to be successful. Governance meetings are quarterly.

Criteria 2.1c: Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors
APPROACHING

Metric 1: Quality of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors show deep knowledge of Arkansas K12 standards, content knowledge, and pedagogy. In the documents provided, the "University of Arkansas School of Education and EPP Faculty Credentials" show that most instructors have a terminal degree, recent professional development, and conference attendance is recorded.

Metric 2: Effectiveness of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors have a history and/or show evidence of strong facilitation of coursework providing feedback and support. From the faculty evaluation materials, it's clear there is an annual evaluation of instructors. Instructors submit evidence and self-assess (implementation of best practices around evaluation). The "Qualtrics UA Little Rock Evaluation Collection of Student Course Evaluation" document illustrates that there is an evaluation process in place for all full-time faculty and adjunct professors.

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Criteria 2.2a: Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher

APPROACHING

Metric 1: The sequence of clinical experiences

APPROACHING

The overall sequence of clinical experiences sometimes builds off previous experiences. It includes opportunities for learning and development, as evidenced in the special education handbook indicating clinical experiences in coursework leading up to the internship experience and in the "Middle Childhood Education Degree Plan," which includes a 12-week internship.

Many teacher candidates in UA Little Rock's graduate program are working professionals. Many of them are already working in schools. They can continue to work as a teacher of record while completing the program's internship component and do not have a sequence to build upon coursework into their clinical experience.

Metric 2: The variety of clinical experiences

APPROACHING

Most teacher candidates in the graduate program take advantage of the online course options, and many teacher candidates live and work across Arkansas as teachers of record. As a teacher of record, they do not get to experience a wide variety of opportunities to work in various settings throughout different clinical internships. However, many programs still require teacher candidates to experience various settings through their classroom experience. For example, special education requires teacher candidates to serve in a school setting with multiple opportunities to work with students ranging from those at risk of academic failure to those who require intensive supportive educational assistance. If a candidate is in a 9- or 12-month position, they work with their clinical supervisor to ensure their placement meets the program's criteria.

Criteria 2.2b: Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship

APPROACHING

Metric 1: The effectiveness of experienced mentor teachers

BELOW

No evidence or observations were collected about the alternative route program's work with mentor teachers and teacher candidates. Several of UA Little Rock's graduate students teach on a provisional license.

Note: By 2026-2027, evidence that experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents have received DESE-recognized coaching training must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 2: Quality of selection process for experienced mentor teachers

BELOW

No evidence or observations were collected about the alternative route program's work with mentor teachers and teacher candidates. Several of UA Little Rock's graduate students teach on a provisional license.

Note: By 2026–2027, evidence that experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents have a minimum 3 years teaching experience, hold a standard Arkansas educators license with a Lead or Master Professional Educator designation, and have evidence of an annual rating of effective or higher in DESE’s Educator Effectiveness System must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 3: Quality of clinical supervisors

MEETS

Most program clinical supervisors show evidence of effective instructional practices and coaching with a positive impact. As evidenced in the documents submitted, all clinical supervisors have experience teaching and coaching and have continued their learning and development.

In the partnership focus group, participants stated that clinical supervisors show evidence of effective instructional practice and coaching by knowing the HQIM utilized by each district and bringing it into their coursework. They also mentioned that the clinical supervisors are highly qualified teachers who provide professional development to candidates during Friday seminar courses.

Metric 4: Quality of feedback to candidates

MEETS

In the documents submitted, the coaching Information spreadsheet outlines multiple feedback and coaching sessions per teaching candidate. The “POP (pre-observation, observation, post-observation) Cycle Feedback” and “Walkthrough Feedback” form document clear templates to deliver feedback to teaching candidates and is aligned to TESS.

Note: By 2024–25, evidence that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is in use by EPPs must be shown to meet this metric.

Criteria 2.2c: Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates

APPROACHING

Metric 1: Quality of partnership with districts/schools

APPROACHING

Due to graduate programs serving teacher candidates through mostly online courses and candidates teaching in classrooms across the state, there is less control over the partner schools where students teach. However, UA Little Rock and partner schools have MOUs in place and open communication channels to support their teacher candidates.

Metric 2: Support and development for clinical supervisors

MEETS

Collaborative processes are consistently in place to support and develop effective clinical supervisors. This is evidenced by documents such as the “US Prep Clinical Convening” document demonstrating work to train supervisors. The clinical supervisors attended supervisor training in San Diego through US Prep.

Clinical supervisors regularly complete professional development and learning opportunities. Staff retreats and faculty agendas show that they frequently meet to discuss findings, data, and program improvements.

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a: Candidates are successful with their program coursework

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate proficiency in coursework

MEETS

Most candidates show proficiency in coursework requirements. Evidence shows that candidates complete coursework requirements using a tracker supplied for the alternative program, and there are examples of two assignments that candidates have completed. In the evidence submitted, the database that shows mastery of coursework shows all but one teaching candidate who graduated with a 3.5 GPA.

Metric 2: Quality of candidate support across coursework

MEETS

Candidates are consistently provided with an individualized support plan if their coursework requirements are not on track. Evidence shows candidates are provided with an individualized support plan if not on track in coursework from the "SOE Student Policies and Procedures Manual" by explaining the process. Two different portfolio assignments are also provided; both are seen as culminating experiences over time. The "Teacher Candidate Growth Plan" outlines a clear plan, action items, and deadlines to support teachers in getting back on track.

Criteria 2.3b: Candidates are successful in their clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate attainment of clinical internship goals and milestones

MEETS

As evidenced in the documents, programs have clear and appropriate goals and milestones for candidates' clinical internships. For example, the POP cycle states clear goals and milestones aligned with the Aspiring TESS indicators. Most students meet the GPA requirement and expectations. Evidence provided shows candidates have goals and milestones for clinical experiences and are recommended for licensure.

Metric 2: Candidate impact on student growth

MEETS

There is adequate evidence that candidates can impact student growth. The evidence details how candidates assess and provide feedback to students about their performance. Additionally, candidates determine how to modify an academic change plan for special education students with various academic needs through pre-assessments, interventions, and post-assessments. This is a required case study for candidates in the special education program. Exit tickets and student polls (Analysis of Student Work evidence) show that students are learning and have a better understanding of the lessons taught.

This was also mentioned in the Program Director focus group. Candidates with field experience develop pre- and post-assessments to assess their ability to impact student growth. These field experiences are tied to the coursework the candidates are enrolled for that semester.

Metric 3: Candidate proficiency in effective teaching skills

MEETS

Most candidates receive an "effective" TESS score. Evidence shows that candidates met the TESS criteria based on average scores. Evidence was provided for candidates' average scores of 3.32, 2.9, 3.11 and 2.97 on the TESS rubric. Additionally, the candidate scored 16 of the 22 components on the Aspiring Teacher Rubric.

Metric 4: Quality of candidate support across clinical internship

APPROACHING

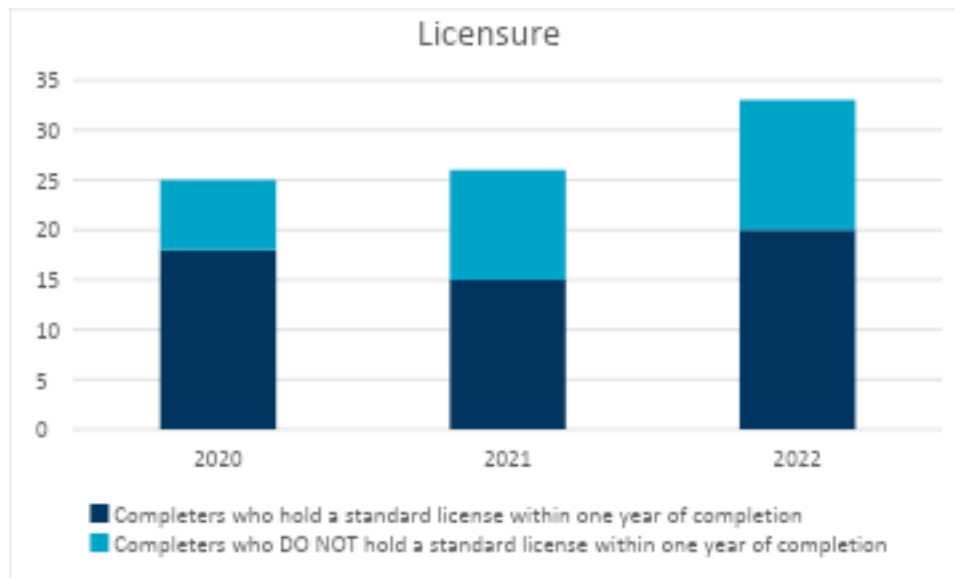
Candidates with varied needs seem to be provided the support they need to succeed throughout their clinical internship. Handbooks are provided for special education programs, and the "School of Education Policy Manual" provides expectations, requirements, and policies. The syllabi provide specific knowledge, skills, and dispositions that are taught based on the candidate's understanding. The "Professional Growth Plan Form" provides evidence of individualized support to candidates if they are off track in their coursework and clinical internships. Clinical supervisors identify areas of concern and expected actions for the teacher candidate to get back on track by a specific date. There is space to make revisions and follow up on progress towards correction. Completed growth plans or growth conversations were not observed during the onsite review. No evidence was submitted that most high-performing candidates receive opportunities and feedback that encourage their retention.

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
BELOW	EXCEEDS	BELOW
Recommendations		
Only a little over half of UA Little Rock's alternative route enrollees who are employed are provisionally licensed, and program completers struggle to become licensed within one year of completion. However, three years after completion, completers become licensed, work in Arkansas public schools and districts (including priority districts and subjects) and stay in the classroom for multiple years. Recommendations include: - Establish programmatic support to ensure that alternative program enrollees who are employed obtain provisional licensure and are prepared to obtain standard licensure immediately following completion. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 3.1a and 3.1b)</i> - Analyze EPP Completer Supervisor Survey and EPP Completer Survey results to identify specific domains and components for which both supervisors and candidates do not feel their program prepared them well to become a teacher. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3a and 3.3b)</i> - Ensure that program completers have the capacity to impact student growth and can demonstrate that capacity in the classroom. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3c)</i>		

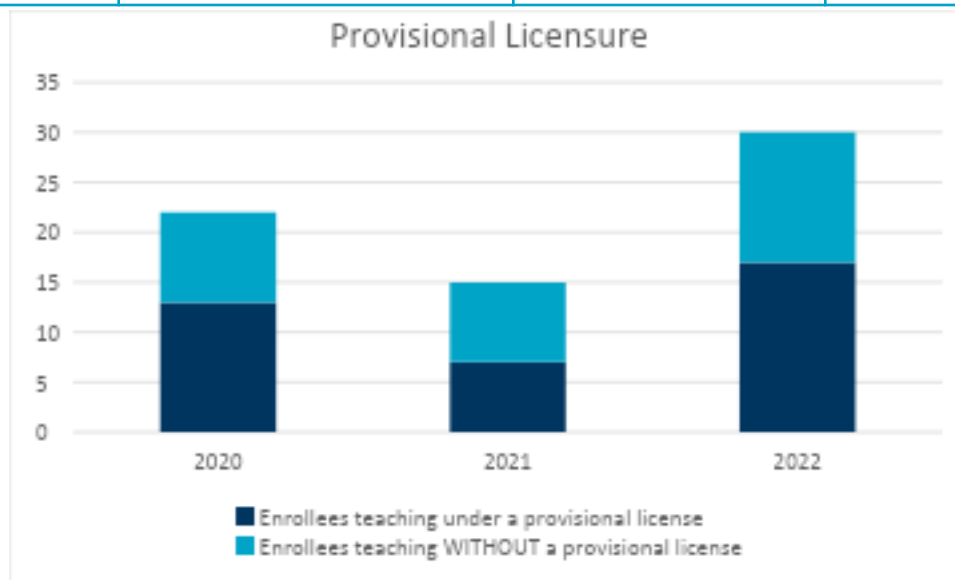
INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a: A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license	76%	63%	BELOW



Criteria 3.1b: A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of employed alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	69%	55.2%	BELOW



Criteria 3.1c: A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try

Metric	Target	EPP's First-Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
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Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	65%	n/a	n/a
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INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

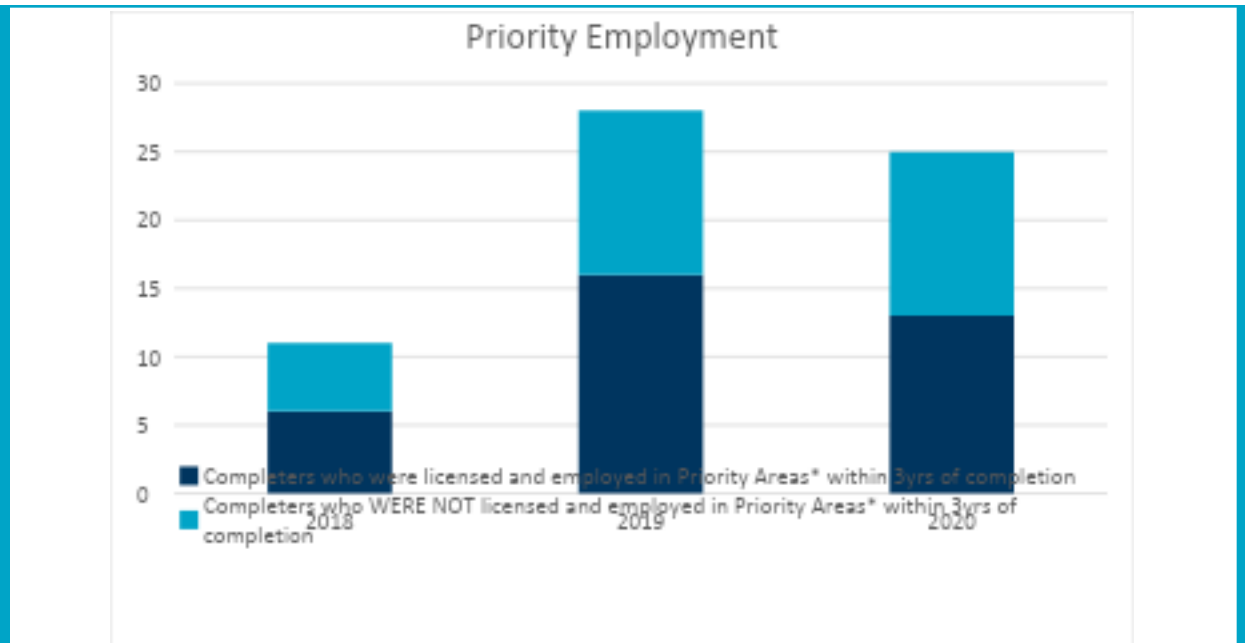
Criteria 3.2a: A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	64%	68.8%	EXCEEDS

Employment

Year	Completers who were licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion	Completers who WERE NOT licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion
2018	6	4
2019	16	8
2020	13	29

■ Completers who were licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion
■ Completers who WERE NOT licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion

Criteria 3.2b: A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	40%	54.7%	EXCEEDS



*Priority Employment is employment in a high-need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) and state focus areas.

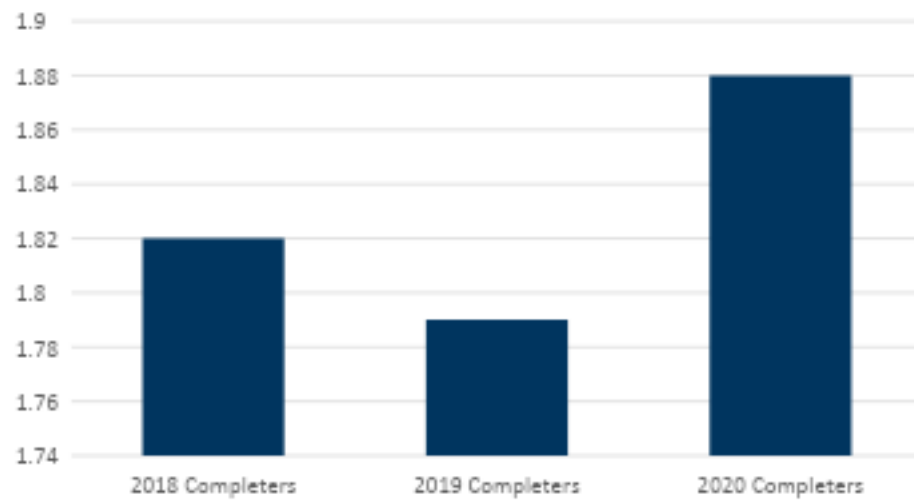
Current subject shortage areas for employment: Computer Science, Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education.

Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.

Criteria 3.2c: Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.7	1.83	EXCEEDS

Average experience three years after completion



INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a: School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by the DESE	81%	66.7%	BELOW
Criteria 3.3b: Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by the DESE	75%	69.2%	APPROACHING
Criteria 3.3c: A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	31%	BELOW

